

BOX OFFICE

Alchemy of Languages

The Indian box office is turning vibrant as Hollywood, Marathi, Punjabi and other non-Hindi films are drawing audiences to the theatres

BY VIDYA S.

28 |

► **WHETHER IT IS** the Marathi film *Baipan Bhari Deva* or the Punjabi movie *Carry on Jatta 3*, a slew of recent Hollywood hits or last year's breakout performance of Kannada films such as *Kantara* and *777 Charlie*, Indian exhibitors are seeing a diverse array of films from different languages drawing crowds to multiplexes.

The numbers say it all. According to India Box Office Report 2023 by consultancy firm Ormax Media, Hindi-language movies accounted for 37 per cent of India's cumulative box office collections from January to June 2023; Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Punjabi and other regional languages together contributed 51 per cent, while Hollywood made up for the rest 12 per cent.

The trend is also clearly visible in the leading multiplex chain Cinépolis India's figures. "Five years ago, English [language movies] contributed to 20 per cent of box office collections, regional films contributed another 20 per cent, while 60 per cent came from Hindi movies alone. This year so far, Bollywood has brought in 50 per cent and the other two categories have gone up to 25 per cent each," says its CEO Devang Sampat.

After the Covid-19 pandemic, theatres in the Hindi-speaking regions struggled to draw audiences back as



51
PER CENT
The contribution of regional language movies to total box office collections during January-June 2023

they were hooked to streaming platforms and back-to-back subpar Hindi films made matters worse. The only saving grace was the phenomenal box office success of South Indian films and their dubbed versions, even in theatres. Since May 2023, it seems the fortunes of theatres, especially multiplexes, have reversed due to hits across languages.

Hollywood set the ball rolling with at least eight big releases since then—*Fast X*, *Spider-Man: Across the Spider-Verse*, *Transformers: Rise of the Beasts*, *The Flash*, *Insidious: The Red Door*, *Mission: Impossible - Dead Reckoning Part One*, *Oppenheimer* and *Barbie*. The last three alone, released in July, have pulled in an estimated total Indian net collection of ₹265 crore and counting. Regional super hits such as 2018 (in Malayalam, released on May 5, collections of ₹92 crore+), *Baipan Bhari Deva* (Marathi, June 30, ₹73 crore+), *Carry on Jatta 3* (Punjabi, June 29, ₹45 crore+) and *Baby* (Telugu, July 14, 2023, ₹63 crore+) have peppered the past three months at the cinemas. Rajinikanth's Tamil movie *Jailer* as well as the Hindi films *Gadar 2* and *OMG 2* made for a triple delight over the Independence Day weekend. "Hollywood and regional films have picked up in a big way," says Nagpur-based exhibitor and distribu-